

3 The Cultivation of Humanity in Confucian Philosophy: Mencius and Xunzi

Confucius' vision for rectifying society was a simple and idealistic one: good government begins in the moral self cultivation of able leaders. At times, the *Analects* acknowledges that the chances of such rectification were minimal (*Analects* 7:26; 9:13). Nevertheless, the ideology of self cultivation (*xiushen*) has had far-reaching effects in Chinese society and culture. The ideology that education begets moral wisdom was articulated in the Chinese Civil Service Examination system. The system, which ran from the Han dynasty (206 BCE–206 CE) up until 1905, recruited men who performed well in examinations based on Confucian texts. It was believed that scholars of the classical texts would also be ethically adept practitioners of good government.

The Confucian theme of self cultivation continues to have contemporary relevance for several reasons. First, it emphasises ethical merit as the basis of government. This is important because it requires government to be accountable. It was a positive change from hereditary leadership which did not ensure competent or ethical leaders. Secondly, it highlights the place of education in social development. Finally, Confucian moral philosophy has vital implications for contemporary moral philosophy due to a number of its key features: attention to character development, centrality of relationships in moral life, the progressive nature of moral development (that is, a focus on different elements of moral reasoning that are cultivated at different stages in a person's moral life), and the integrated nature of personal development and socio-political progress.

The Confucians were optimistic, yet pragmatic, in their assessment of human moral capacities and how these could be shaped to produce more fruitful outcomes for society. The theory of self cultivation played a central role in the Confucian hope for a better, more ethically focused society. Both Mencius (385?–312? BCE) and Xunzi (310?–219? BCE), thinkers belonging to the Confucian school, had to defend Confucian thought as different schools of

thought emerged and evolved during the Warring States period. As a result, they sought ways to justify this vision, mainly by constructing an account of original human nature that required further development.

Mencius, one of the prominent early second-generation disciples of Confucius, argued that human nature is originally good. According to Mencius, malevolence was due to various extraneous factors that had led humans astray from their original natures. Hence, rectification was required to recover the lost originally good nature. Xunzi countered that human nature was morally bad to begin with and that it needed to be corrected to avoid the further disintegration of the human condition. The debate on the original state of human nature and its cultivation developed much further both within and outside the Confucian school. The disagreements between Mencius and Xunzi shaped the early development of Confucian philosophy after Confucius.

Mencius: The Cultivation of Human Nature

Mencius is thought to have studied with a pupil of Confucius' grandson, Zisi (483?–402? BCE).¹ He is the author of the second set of books in the Confucian canon, the *Four Books* (*Si Shu*).² His philosophy is optimistically humanistic as he believed that humans had inherent goodness. On this thesis, he built his theory of compassionate government (*ren zheng*). A famous story attributes Mencius' optimistic philosophy to his overwhelmingly positive experience of motherly love. The short, cryptic phrase captures his philosophy of human goodness: "human nature is good" (*xing shan*) (*Books of Mencius* 6A:6). Mencius dismisses other views on the connection between morality and human nature (*xing*):

Kung-tu Tzu [Gongduzi] said, 'Kao Tzu [Gaozi] said, "There is neither good nor bad in human nature," but others say, "Human nature can become good or it can become bad, and that is why with the rise of King Wen [Wan] and King Wu, the people were given to goodness, while with the rise of King Yu and King Li, they were given to cruelty." Then there are others who say, "There are those who are good by nature, and there are those who are bad by nature. For this reason, Hsiang [Xiang] could have Yao as Prince, and Shun could have the Blind Man [Gu Sou] as father, and Ch'i [Qi], Viscount of Wei and Prince Pi Kan [Bi Gan] could have Tchou [Zhou] as nephew as well as sovereign." Now you say human nature is good. Does this mean that all the others are mistaken?' (*Books of Mencius* 6A:6, trans. Lau 1979b: 247)

The different conceptions of human nature that stand in contrast to Mencius' include:

- (a) Morality is not an intrinsic part of human nature.
- (b) Humans are born as a blank slate, a *tabula rasa*. They become good or bad depending on the influences around them.
- (c) Some humans are born intrinsically good and others intrinsically bad.

The differences between the views in (a) and (b) are subtle: (a) emphatically dissociates morality from human nature while (b) focuses on the malleability and vulnerability of humans to external influences. The view in (c) expressly denies Mencius' assertion that goodness is a universal characteristic of humanity. When asked to clarify his position that human nature is good, Mencius begins with the refutation of Gaozi's (ca. 420–350 BCE) view that morality is not inherent in human nature.³ In his extended responses, Mencius provides various analogies for an inborn moral nature – such as, for instance, that the flow of water from a higher level to a lower one is the inherent nature of water (*Books of Mencius* 6A:2). Mencius seems to assume that these analogies are adequate for the purpose, although they are merely an extended elaboration of his view.

The view (c), that innate moral characteristics or propensities are variable across individuals, also poses a problem for Mencius' theory. For Mencius, it is important that intrinsic goodness is universal because he also wants to maintain that all humans are potentially perfectible, regardless of hereditary status⁴: 'The sage and I are of the same kind', Mencius boldly proclaims (*Books of Mencius* 6A:7; trans. Lau 1979b: 249). He provides analogies of common human experiences – a liking for good flavours, sounds and sights – to support his argument that goodness is also a shared characteristic. The *irrelevance* of hereditary status to moral cultivation (and, ultimately, to involvement in good government) was an important underlying theme in Confucius' and Mencius' philosophies as it was in their personal lives. As common men without noble birthright, it is not surprising that they should assert this.

Mencius also attempted to provide a transcendent basis for a moral human nature. He identified that as the source of human goodness and asserted a unity between heaven and humanity⁵:

For a man to give full realization to his heart [*xin*] is for him to understand his own nature, and a man who knows his own nature will know Heaven [*tian*]. By

retaining his heart and nurturing his nature he is serving Heaven... (*Books of Mencius* 7A:1, trans. Lau 1979b: 287).

Mencius' aim was not to explore cosmic or spiritual concepts but simply to use the notion of heaven as a transcendent basis of human capacities and potential. However, we need to be careful in applying the term 'transcendent' to Mencius' concept of human nature. Mencius sought to locate the source of human goodness in *tian*, a source *more* fundamental than humanity itself; in that sense we may say that *tian* is the transcendent basis for human goodness. Yet, in another sense, the relation between *tian* and human nature is a closely intertwined one, interdependent rather than independent: the person who preserves (the goodness of) his heart-mind, *xin*, and who cultivates his nature is engaged in one and the same process of serving *tian*. As this passage reveals *xin*, the heart-mind, is the clue to understanding Mencius' conception of human nature. *Xin* in Mencius' philosophy is commonly translated 'heart', although the concept covers a set of capacities rather than an organ.⁶ The set of capacities is both an intrinsic and a distinctive feature of humanity (*Books of Mencius* 2A:6; 4B:19; 6A:8). We should also note that Mencius did not distinguish deliberative morality from emotion (in the way we might find, say, in Plato's philosophy); hence the term *xin* is best translated as heart-mind. *Xin* is the seat of intellect, cognition, emotion and affection. It seemed to him both commonsensical and profound that the child who appreciated and understood her parents' love would reciprocate that concern and eventually extend it to others (*Books of Mencius* 7A:15). Emotion and moral sensitivity were, for him, deeply connected with moral deliberation. For Mencius, the task of moral cultivation was to re-ignite the lost heart-mind.

Mencius set out four basic manifestations of *xin*: *ren* (sympathy and compassion), *yi* (moral sense or rightness), *li* (respect resulting from recognising different relations and hierarchies) and *zhi* (wisdom) (*Books of Mencius* 2A:6). In characteristic style, Mencius does not provide justification for his selection of the four basic characteristics. Chad Hansen suggests that one problem in Mencius' theory of human nature is not that the four shoots of goodness are not universal features of the human psyche, but, rather, that they are far too specific: Mencius has not provided adequate justification for his selection of these traits as innately human.⁷

There is considerable co-referencing between *xin* and *xing* (human nature) in *Books of Mencius* so that it is at times difficult to articulate the difference

between them.⁸ This laxity in part reflects that Mencius believes *xin* is at the core of humanity. However, what is philosophically significant is whether Mencius' 'original' goodness is to be understood as an innate disposition toward goodness or the possession of a capacity that may be developed.

The first assertion, that goodness is an innate disposition, is the stronger one. Mencius' example of how *any* person would feel distress at seeing a child about to fall into a well and spontaneously attempt to save the child captures the essence of this view (*Books of Mencius* 2A:6. See also 6A:10). That there is a spontaneous desire to do what is good suggests a naturalistic and deterministic account of human goodness.⁹ Defenders of this interpretation of human nature would be hard-pressed to provide reasons for greed, selfishness and evil. On the other hand, it is difficult fully to dismiss this interpretation because there are hints of this view in some of Mencius' discussions.

The second, weaker, interpretation holds that humans possess a *capacity* for developing a sense of goodness. If this capacity – or capacities, as the case may be – is not properly cultivated, it will easily be overcome by the adverse influences in society. In the famous discussion of the trees of the Niu Mountain, Mencius draws an analogy between the nourishment and care that trees should have and the moral cultivation of human nature (*Books of Mencius* 6A:8). A critical point of the analogy is the necessity of consistent and continual cultivation.

As there is support in the *Books of Mencius* text for both interpretations, some scholars take the middle ground and contend that *xing* embodies a dual meaning.¹⁰ According to this view, *xing* refers *both* to an incipient capacity *and* its continuing cultivation. A. C. Graham explains the meaning of *xing* with reference to its etymology. Its right half consists of the character *sheng*, which means both birth and growth. Graham also refers to a general imprecision of Chinese concepts in order to explain *xing*:

Mencius in particular seems never to be looking back towards birth, always forward to the maturation of a continuing growth. This accords with one's general impression when groping towards an understanding of early Chinese concepts, that often they tend to be more dynamic than their nearest Western equivalents, and that English translation freezes them into immobility.¹¹

Mencius' theory of human nature begins positively in a universal incipient goodness; it culminates in an optimistic vision of an ethical, well-governed

society. Although many aspects of Mencius' philosophy are riddled with questionable analogies, the tenor of his ideas and the aspiration toward a humane, benevolent government would have had much popular appeal in the climate of war and terror then. Additionally, his writings provide rich material for debates in philosophy, anthropology and moral psychology.

Xunzi: The Regulation of Human Behaviour

Xunzi is often hailed as the most scrupulous of the early Confucian philosophers because of the rigour in his argumentation. Recognition of Xunzi's intellectual prowess extended well beyond the Confucian school. He was well regarded at Jixia, where thinkers of different persuasions congregated to debate issues. In his authored work, the thirty-two-chapter *Works of Hsun Tzu* [Xunzi] text, Xunzi argued against the views of Legalist thinkers such as Shen Buhai and Shen Dao, the Daoist thinker Zhuangzi, the Mohist Mozi and the dialecticians, notably, Gongsun Long. However, Xunzi did not simply reject each of these views. Instead, he synthesised what he believed were important elements from these different philosophies with his personal Confucian convictions.

For example, Confucius rejected penal law (*fa*) as an instrument of cultivation (*Analects* 2:3; 12:13). But Xunzi was more realistic in endorsing the deterrent effects of *fa* as he believed that the method of positive reinforcement alone was inadequate for transforming society. In contrast to Mencius' positive assessment of human nature, Xunzi's views are notably pessimistic. His treatise on *xing* is entitled 'Xing E', that is, 'Human Nature is Evil' or 'Human Nature is Base'. Xunzi poses a counter-example to Mencius' child-about-to-fall-into-a-well example. He visualises two brothers vying for property, each of whom is self-serving at best. Xunzi notes that such selfishness is pervasive and argues for reform through a highly regulated socio-political context. He begins with a bleak postulation about the severe lack of moral goodness in original human nature:

Man's nature (*xing*) is evil; goodness is the result of conscious activity. The nature of man is such that he is born with a fondness for profit... He is born with feelings of envy and hate... Hence, any man who follows his nature and indulges his emotions will inevitably become involved in wrangling and strife, will violate the forms and rules of society, and will end as a criminal. (*Works of Hsun Tzu* 23: 'The Nature of Man is Evil' trans. Watson 1963: 157)

Xunzi is not merely claiming that human nature is non-moral. He emphasises the *actively* selfish character of *xing* and its antisocial effects. Xunzi is often criticised for holding the view that human nature is ‘evil’ – and indeed, conventional translations of his theory of human nature interpret ‘e’ as *evil*. Xunzi’s philosophy, however, does not incorporate the elements of degenerateness or depravity we commonly associate with the concept of evil that has arisen from the Judaeo-Christian tradition. If we look carefully at this passage, it suggests that what Xunzi is concerned about is not inherent evil as such, but selfishness. Here, he seems to be saying that human nature is inherently selfish, and selfishness has undesirable outcomes. Selfishness results in strife and hatred and creates negative consequences not only for society but for the selfish person himself. This is detrimental and has negative consequences for society.

The disagreements between Mencius and Xunzi generate important philosophical and ethical questions. The difference in the views may be attributed to differences in the respective notions of *xing*.¹² There are also differences in their methods of moral cultivation. Mencius advocates the nurturing of socially positive behaviours while Xunzi believes primarily in instituting deterrents against antisocial behaviours. Moral cultivation in Mencius’ view for the most part involves understanding the problem of the lost *xin* (mind–heart) and how it might be restored (*Books of Mencius* 6A:11, 12). Hence, Mencius states explicitly that the office of *xin* is to reflect and contemplate (*si*) (*Books of Mencius* 6A:15).¹³ On the other hand, Xunzi advocates a more extensive program which underlines arduous practice and learning from external sources: goodness is the result of coordinated social regulation (*Works of Hsun Tzu* 23: ‘The Nature of Man is Evil’). Xunzi believes that moral cultivation consists essentially in compliance with standards for behaviour such as *li* and *fa*. While a benevolent government is critical in Mencius’ philosophy, Xunzi’s system calls for an ethical regulator.

Li (Appropriate Behaviour) and *Fa* (Standards and Penal Law)

Xunzi argues against a programme that relies solely on eliciting other-regarding behaviour and feelings:

Now the nature of man is evil. It must depend on teachers and laws (*fa*) to become correct and achieve propriety (*li*) and righteousness (*yi*)... The sage-kings of antiquity, knowing that the nature of man is evil, and

that it is unbalanced, off the track, incorrect, rebellious, disorderly, and undisciplined, created the rules of propriety and righteousness and instituted laws and systems in order to correct man's feelings, transform them, and direct them ... (*Works of Hsun Tzu* 23: 'The Nature of Man is Evil' trans. Chan 1963a: 128)

Li encourages positive (altruistic) behaviours while *fa*, the system of penal law enforced through punishment, discourages negative behaviours. *Li* and *fa* are complementary instruments for socio-political order (*Works of Hsun Tzu* 9: 'The Regulations of a King'). They work in tandem, *li* to encourage altruistic tendencies and *fa* to curb selfish ones. Xunzi meticulously investigates the origins of *li* and its applications; he eloquently expresses the sense of proportion and restraint brought about by implementing *li*:

Rites [*li*] trim what is too long and stretch out what is too short, eliminate surplus and repair deficiency, extend the forms of love and reverence, and step by step bring to fulfilment the beauties of proper conduct. Beauty and ugliness, music and weeping, joy and sorrow are opposites, and yet rites make use of them all, bringing forth and employing each in its turn. (*Works of Hsun Tzu* 19: 'A Discussion of Ritual' trans. Watson 1963: 100)

Li is instrumental in the realisation of social harmony as it helps to mark each person's place within networks of relationships (*Works of Hsun Tzu* 14). Homer Dubs, who was a Chinese intellectual historian, captures the breadth of scope and versatility of Xunzi's *li*:

Li is human emotion expressed, harmonized, and beautified so as to become a pattern for all. It uses the features, the voice, food, garments, and dwellings, and gives each their appropriate means of expressing emotion. As a pattern, *Li* aids those whose expression of sorrow would be too little, and those whose expression of sorrow would be too violent, alike to reach a golden mean. By means of *Li*, the degenerate son is kept from becoming worse than a beast, and the over-sensitive man is prevented from injuring himself. *Li* is the beautifying of man's original nature by means of acquired characteristics which could not be acquired of themselves. (trans. Dubs 1966: 146–7)

Dubs's description of *li* in Xunzi's philosophy captures Xunzi's idea of regulation. This conception of *li* is subtly different from its use both in the *Analects* and *Books of Mencius*. The *Analects* maintains a connection between *ren* (human feeling) and *li* (its expression), while the *Books of Mencius* unifies *ren* and

li with moral discrimination and practical wisdom. In both these texts, *li* is primarily aligned with the cultivation of human moral sentiment. But Xunzi links *li* with *fa* and imputes the former with a stronger sense of compliance. This was a major point of departure from Confucius' thinking: Confucius understood *li* and *fa* to be based in fundamentally different conceptions of human good and social development. He claimed to be good at litigation while using it only as a last resort (*Analects* 12:13). A.C. Graham expresses Confucius' sentiments succinctly: 'Confucius accepts law as belonging to government, but measures success in ruling by how little it is necessary to apply it' (1989: 14). In comparison, Xunzi's approach to moral order is both more comprehensive and more cautious in its assumptions about human nature. His proposal for external regulation of behaviours appears to be a more viable system as contrasted with the naïveté in Mencius' idealistic humanism.

Zhengming: Regulating Society with Prescribed Titles

Another aspect of Xunzi's proposal relates to his debates with the dialecticians about names and their connection with reality. As we will see in a later chapter, the dialectician Gongsun Long emphasised the absolute nature of titles, assigning them a status akin to Platonic universals.¹⁴ This debate on names and their connection with the world was a major issue that preoccupied thinkers from the fourth century BCE. The discussions covered topics in metaphysics, epistemology, philosophy of language and ethics. Confucius was engrossed with the use of titles to establish normative relationship obligations (*Analects* 12:11; 12:19; 13:3). For Confucius, *zhengming* is not primarily concerned with abstract, theoretical issues pertaining to the connection between names and reality nor is it about the modification of titles, as its common translation 'rectification of names' suggests. *Zhengming* in Confucian philosophy is an ethical theory concerning the appropriate conduct of those who bear particular titles.¹⁵ Confucius seems to subscribe to a fundamental normative reality that language-terms must correspond with, and further propagate. But Xunzi rejects this assumption and contends that there is no mystery associated with the origin of names as their meanings are merely customary:

Names have no intrinsic appropriateness. One agrees to use a certain name and issues an order to that effect, and if the agreement is abided by and

becomes a matter of custom, then the name may be said to be appropriate, but if people do not abide by the agreement, then the name ceases to be appropriate. Names have no intrinsic reality. One agrees to use a certain name and issues an order that it shall be applied to a certain reality, and if the agreement is abided by and becomes a matter of custom, then it may be said to be a real name. (*Works of Hsun Tzu* 22: 'The Rectification of Names', trans. Watson 1963: 138)

In Xunzi's account, there is more responsibility attributed to the ruler and the leaders in society for the education of the people.¹⁶ He is deeply conscious of the extent of influence wielded by those in power. The creation of standards through the determination of word-meanings is a powerful instrument with which entire populations may be swayed and managed. Xunzi astutely suggests that the role of government is not to encourage people not to have desires¹⁷ but rather to manage the people's expectations such that '[although] one may not be able to enjoy all the most beautiful things in the world...yet he can still increase his joy... This is what it means to value the self and make other things work for you' (*ibid.*: 155–6).

In their responses to the socio-political unrest, Mencius and Xunzi begin from opposing assumptions. Mencius seeks to build upon an embryonic assumption, shared by the early Confucian disciples, of goodness inherent in humanity. He optimistically projects that human society will flourish if these sprouts of goodness are nurtured. Xunzi, on the other hand, postulates original selfishness to justify his recommendation for standards and measures such as *li* and *fa* to be enforced. Nevertheless he makes propitious projections for a society of people tempered by socio-political institutions: moral training and development can effectively overcome tendencies toward selfish indulgence. Burton Watson comments on the contrast between Xunzi's original nature and its subsequent development: 'To this dark initial thesis Hsün Tzu [Xunzi] contraposes the almost unlimitedly bright possibilities for improvement through study and moral training' (*ibid.*: 5). The early Confucians believed that all humans were morally perfectible and Xunzi was no exception in that regard. He states, unambiguously, that self cultivation is a real possibility for all humans. His statement is filled with conviction:

The man in the street can become a Yu. What does this mean? What made the sage emperor Yu a Yu, I would reply, was the fact that he practiced

benevolence and righteousness and abided by the proper rules and standards...Any man in the street has the essential faculties needed to understand benevolence, righteousness, and proper standards, and the potential ability to put them into practice. (*Works of Hsun Tzu* 23 'Human Nature is Evil', trans. Watson 1963: 166–7).

Both Mencius' and Xunzi's commitment to the perfectibility of the common man would have been radical within a social environment that was highly conscious of rank and status. Both blatantly assert the equality of all human beings. The notion of equality held by Mencius and Xunzi not only discredits the belief in *natural* inequality (that is, inequalities due to birthright or nobility) but also attacks existing inequalities. They challenge hereditary authority and replace it with an ethical meritocracy. Many of the chapters in the *Analects*, the *Books of Mencius* and the *Works of Hsun Tzu* are explicitly critical of existing socio-political structures and of those in power then. The model of government they propose involves an extensive engineering of human community.

The Way of Heaven and the Way of Humanity

The early Confucian thinkers did not provide a thorough justification for their vision of good government. More specifically, the rationale for its programme, including for the installation of *li* and *zhengming*, is not clearly articulated in the early texts. In the case of Mencius, we know that the basis of benevolent government lies in the abilities and intuitions of the benevolent ruler, but little more than that. Ultimately, these intuitions are grounded in heaven, as we have seen in *Books of Mencius* 7A:1. Mencius believed it was important to locate the ground of human well-being in a fundamental source. In expounding on the necessity for self cultivation, he needed to draw together these two elements: heaven and humanity. His method was to identify heaven as the source of human goodness (specifically, *xin*, the mind–heart). The task in self cultivation was to draw on this endowment in order to improve on human well-being.

In the seminal Confucian text the *Doctrine of the Mean* (*Zhongyong*), we see further development of the theme of cooperation between heaven and humanity.¹⁸ The *Zhongyong* is a treatise on human and cosmic harmony, dealing with how equilibrium (*zhong*) and commonality (*yong*) are attained. The

fundamental value in the *Zhongyong* is sincerity (*xin*), which is heaven's way. The practice of perfect sincerity by humans brings together a tripartite unity of heaven, earth and humanity. The comprehensiveness of this doctrine can only be understood when we view *Zhongyong* chapter 22 in its entirety:

Only that one in the world who is most perfectly sincere is able to give full development to his nature. Being able to give full development to his nature, he is able to give full development to the nature of other human beings and, being able to give full development to the nature of other human beings, he is able to give full development to the natures of other living things. Being able to give full development to the natures of other living things, he can assist in the transforming and nourishing powers of Heaven and Earth; being able to assist in the transforming and nourishing powers of Heaven and Earth; he can form a triad with Heaven and Earth. (De Bary and Bloom 1999: 338)

We will understand more fully the early Confucian debate about human nature if we also examine Yang Zhu's doctrine of *xing*. Mencius is adamant that Yang Zhu's egoism is detrimental to society because he renounces the authority of the ruler in favour of looking after oneself (*Books of Mencius* 3B:9). Yang Zhu is described in the *Liezi* (c. 300 CE) as utterly selfish, unable directly to answer the question, 'If you could help the whole world at the cost of one hair of your body, would you do it?' (Graham 1978: 16; *Books of Mencius* 7A:26). Due to this representation, Yang Zhu's theory has often been ignored in serious scholarship. However, Graham points out the probable misrepresentation of the theory and how Yang Zhu's ideas are in fact important in understanding the twin issues of human nature and self cultivation. According to Graham, an earlier text, the *Lüshi Chunqiu* (*Master Lü's Spring and Autumn Annals*; c. 240 BCE), presents a different account of individualist thought (Graham 1978: 16–7). The main strands of this doctrine include keeping intact what heaven has bestowed, nourishing it and not interfering with it. This does not necessarily imply excessive selfishness but rather advocates 'nurturing and harmonising the vital tendencies and spontaneous inclinations which Heaven instilled in us when we were born' (*ibid.*: 17).

If Graham is correct, Yang Zhu's doctrine espouses a much closer connection between heaven and humanity than we see in the early Confucian theories. For Yang Zhu, one must be watchful that external factors are prevented from interfering with this original nature. In Mencius' philosophy, external factors are more differentiated: there are those which are detrimental to

human well-being and others, such as benevolent leadership, which foster harmony and human development. The latter, positive, elements must be encouraged and individuals must be receptive to the guiding influences of the benevolent ruler. Graham presents the Yang Zhu–early Confucian debate thus:

It had never been questioned that Heaven, the power responsible for all things being as they are, for the uncontrollable accidents of fortune and misfortune, for whatever in man is innate and independent of his will, has also ordained the principles by which we should live. ... Now for the first time [in Confucian and Mohist thought] a metaphysical doubt enters Chinese thought, and a rift opens between Heaven and man, between what is and what should be. If Heaven is on the side of Yang Chu [Yang Zhu], on what is the morality of Confucians and Mohists to rest? (Graham 1978: 17)

The rift between heaven and humanity is even wider in Xunzi's philosophy. Xunzi devotes a chapter in his text to the discussion of heaven (Chapter 17, 'Discourse on Heaven' (*tianlun*)). There, he limits the jurisdiction of heaven to a natural order that does not intervene in human affairs. Also in the same chapter, he takes care to dispel superstitions – for instance, about eclipses and climate changes – in order to promote active responsibility of humans for socio-political affairs. As with the other Confucians, Xunzi emphasises the unity between heaven, earth and humanity. However, it is a rather detached version of the tripartite relationship in that the domains of the three are clearly defined, rather than overlapping. We see especially in Xunzi's philosophy an emphasis on human initiative in planning for and structuring a nation.

Personal Cultivation and Social Development

The early Confucian thinkers were working toward a humanistic government that looked upon the needs of the people as its first priority. Unfortunately, this important theme is often ignored in many popular renditions of Confucianism, where the focus is on leadership without mention of moral accountability. The Confucians were devoted to learning and cultivation, and committed to optimising the human condition through socio-political infrastructure. The ideal society was built upon the exemplary and paradigmatic commitment of the government to the people, especially in Mencius' philosophy.

In early Confucian philosophy, the cultivation of the self is primarily a directed process, coordinated by those with moral and political authority. In fact, for Confucius, moral and political capability are two integrated aspects of those in government. In this regard, one concern often articulated by critics is the collectivist nature of Confucian ideology. The worry is that the priority given to collective (for example, national or familial) well-being will always override individual interests and needs. This concern is not insignificant in the light of events in Chinese history – if indeed the cause may at least in part be attributed to Confucianism. The important question for contemporary Confucian scholars is whether there are elements in Confucian philosophy that uphold the basic integrity of the self. Some scholars such as Tu Weiming have sought the answer in a broader adapted understanding of self cultivation.¹⁹ He argues that the cultivation of the self is not merely to blend into one's relational roles:

The self as the center of relationships has always been the focus of Confucian learning. One's ability to harmonize human relations does indeed indicate one's self-cultivation, but the priority is clearly set. Self-cultivation is a precondition for harmonizing human relations; if human relations are superficially harmonized without the necessary ingredients of self-cultivation, it is practically unworkable and teleologically misdirected. (1985: 55–6)

Tu attempts to alleviate the concern that Confucian self cultivation is merely an acculturation process. Yet, we must be careful not to fragment the concept of self cultivation by identifying first- and second-order priorities or prerequisites: first the self, then its relationships. It is more accurate to characterise the Confucian concept of self as primarily a related self; this means that cultivation of good relationships will ultimately benefit the self. Indeed, Tu himself breaks the self–other and the individual–collective dichotomy in another essay:

...Confucian self-transformation is based on neither isolated self-control nor collective social sanction. It is in what may be called the “between” that its basis really lies ... the main issue in Confucianism is never conceived of in terms of an “either-or” proposition. Rather, to be an authentic man is to be truthful to *both* one's selfhood and one's sociality. (1972: 192–3)

In Confucian philosophy, relationships are integral to and constitutive of a person's identity. This concept of self is essentially as a related entity that

thrives on mutually beneficial relationships. It stands in contrast to those accounts of self that value detached impartiality or stoical, self-denying altruism. Confucian philosophy emphasises the basic interrelatedness of persons as a central feature of its account of morality. According to this view, self cultivation is the ethico-social realisation of individuals within their networks of relationships. The success of the Confucian vision relies on the interest of individuals in their shared well-being. The nature of cooperation and collaboration within Confucian society has been likened to musicians playing in concert. Every member of the ensemble has an important role to play, and a good performance is assessed not merely with reference to the ability of each of the players with respect to their roles, but also to how well the musicians play together.²⁰ The Confucian interdependent self deserves serious consideration as it provides rich insights into the centrality of human interaction and relationships in the lives of individuals. The concept of the interdependent self is a realistic account of self and one that has important implications for notions of action, intentionality, responsibility, accountability, choice and morality.

Character Development and the Cultivation of Skills

The person who has advanced a fair way into the self cultivation process will have developed inner resources that are independent of contemporary norms. *Analects* 13:23 notes that the *junzi*, the Confucian paradigmatic person,²¹ does not seek to be similar to other people, although he aims to be harmonious with them:

The *chun tzu* [*junzi*] seeks to be harmonious (*he*) but does not attempt to be similar (*tong*). The small man, by contrast, seeks to be similar and is not harmonious (trans. Lau 1979a: 122).

Both in the description of Confucius' developmental path (*Analects* 2:4) and the *junzi*'s achievements (*Analects* 15:21; 15:22), there is a sense of the paradigmatic person's detachment from conventional norms and expectations:

The Master said, "You can study with some, and yet not necessarily walk the same path (*dao* 道); you can walk the same path as some, and yet not necessarily take your stand with them; you can take your stand with them,

and yet not necessarily weigh things up in the same way.” (*Analects* 9:30; trans. Ames and Rosemont, Jr 1998a: 133)

The paradigmatic person is a discriminating thinker who critically evaluates the beliefs, norms and practices of his society. He is a creator of standards rather than a follower (*Analects* 2:1; 12:19) and he possesses a keen sense of moral discrimination (*Analects* 4:3). For the *junzi*,

[m]oral life is displayed not as a set of court-judgments on specifiable actions but rather as the development of relationships, skills, and ongoing virtues that make it possible to affect things for the better at the right time and in the right way. The power of this point derives from its contrast to the usual Western mode of moral thinking. Perhaps because of the pervasiveness of the juridical model, Western philosophers have looked at the judgeable action as the proper unit of moral worth. (Neville 1986: 191)

The training required to attain the skills of moral deliberation is extensive. It involves the cultivation of a range of capacities with the following features:

- (1) Reading and reflecting to arouse one’s sensibilities and sharpen critical skills (*Analects* 17:9).
- (2) Reflective self-examination (*Analects* 15:6) of one’s dealings with others (*Analects* 1:4) as well as a mindful attitude toward all matters (19:6; 16:10).
- (3) Observation of the practices and conduct of others. Confucius was a keen observer of others’ behaviours (*Analects* 2:10) and he learnt from both the good and the bad (*Analects* 7:22).
- (4) Commitment to constant practice (*Analects* 19:5; 12:1) with a view to making manifest one’s fundamental principles. This idea is captured in the concept *xin*, often translated ‘sincerity’ or ‘trustworthiness’. *Xin* is an integral component in Confucian self cultivation (*Analects* 1:4–8; 9:24–25; 12:10; 14:37), once being described as the pin of a yoke that enables a carriage to be drawn (*Analects* 2:22).

We must not overstate the case for the independence of the paradigmatic person from his or her traditional culture. The paradigmatic person is attuned to the norms within her community (*Analects* 14:29), sensitive to others and aware of morally significant contextual factors. Hence, moral development

includes the inculcation of a sense of shame (primarily, *xiu* and *chi* in the early Confucian texts), an internal consciousness that is uneasy when one has done bad things especially in the ‘eyes of others’.²² She also has a broad knowledge and understanding of situations in life, a depth of experience including learning from the experiences of others, and the deliberative skills required in making moral judgments. David Nivison, a contemporary scholar, argues that the question of self cultivation centres on the inculcation of moral sensitivity, which he terms *de* (virtue):

...the focus (in Confucian ethics) is not on how to define the good or the right, or to determine what is good or right; these things will seem unproblematic. The real problem seems to be how one becomes a person who has *de*; and this means that the moral tradition is centered from the start on self-cultivation and on how one conveys insight to a student or gets the student to change. (1999: 750)

Just as one might learn from the *Book of Odes* (also known as the *Book of Poetry*) during Confucius’ time, the contemporary reader of the *Analects* may reflect on a range of skills as they are played out in its different passages. The passages provide a sense of the complexity and immediacy of different moral dilemmas. Each situation presents issues with different moral weights and competing obligations to be fulfilled. These insights familiarise the reader with an understanding of different obligations, loyalties and relational distance in his relationships with others. Especially in a harsh social environment, loyalties and support networks are an integral part of good relationships and are instrumental in pulling individuals through difficult moments. The application of these insights could assist in the cultivation of some fundamental skills in ethical reflection and deliberation.

Suggestions for Further Reading

Mencius, translated by Dim-Cheuk Lau (1979), revised edition, Hong Kong: The Chinese University Press.

Hsün Tzu: Basic Writings, translated by Burton Watson (1963), New York: Columbia University Press.

Xunzi: A Translation and Study of the Complete Works, translated by John Knoblock, vols. 1–3. vol. 1 (1988) books 1–6; vol. 2 (1990) books 7–16; vol. 3 (1994) books 17–32, Stanford: Stanford University Press.

- Chan, Alan (editor) (2002) *Mencius: Contexts and Interpretations*, Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press.
- Cua, Antonio (2005) *Human Nature, Ritual, and History: Studies in Xunzi and Chinese Philosophy* (Studies in Philosophy and the History of Philosophy), Washington, D.C.: Catholic University of America Press.
- Shun, Kwong-Loi (1997) *Mencius and Early Chinese Thought*, Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Notes

1. Refer to Wing-tsit Chan 1963a: 49.
2. The Confucian canon, the *Four Books* (*Si Shu*), were codified by the Neo-Confucian Zhu Xi (1130–1200). These four books (the *Great Learning* (*Daxue*), the *Analects* (*Lunyu*), the *Books of Mencius* and the *Doctrine of the Mean* (*Zhongyong*)) comprised the core of the official curriculum of the civil service examinations during the Yuan (1279–1368) and Ming (1368–1644) dynasties.
3. Kwong-Loi Shun presents a detailed analysis of Mencius' discussions with Gaozi, including philosophical details of their debates (1997: 87–94). Little is known of Gaozi's background and associations. Shun discusses a number of theses regarding his philosophical affiliations at pp. 123ff.
4. Chad Hansen notes that Mencius' view of human nature is far more optimistic than that set out in the *Analects* (Hansen 1992: 71ff.).
5. Mencius' strategy of grounding *xing* in *tian* resonates with the themes espoused in the *Zhongyong*. The *Zhongyong* is a classical Confucian text, also one of the Confucian *Four Books*, reputedly written by Confucius' grandson, Zisi, although some of it appears to have earlier origins, while other parts date from as late as the early Han period. Tu Weiming presents a metaphysical and religious interpretation of Confucian self cultivation based on the *Zhongyong* (Tu 1976).
6. In contemporary Chinese it can refer both to intellectual-moral capacity, the mind, as well as the physical organ, the heart.
7. Hansen writes, 'The empirical problem is not that his theory is implausibly optimistic as much as that it is implausibly specific about the innate judgments of what counts as good.' (1992: 168).
8. Benjamin Schwartz notes that 'the center of Mencius' problematique in dealing with man is really *not* the nature [*xing*] but the heart/mind [*xin*]' (1985: 266). See also Schwartz 1985: 288ff.; Ch'en, 1953; Ahern 1980: 183; and Graham 1967.
9. See, for example, Creel 1953: 88.
10. Schwartz 1985: 266 and Ho Hwang 1979: 201–9.

11. A. C. Graham (1990b) *Studies in Chinese Philosophy and Philosophical Literature*, 7. The *Shuowen Jiezi* also emphasises the derivative meaning of *xing* from *sheng*, growth. Further, it states that the term derives from *xin*, the heart-mind (at p. 502). These derivatives taken together suggest cultivation, a continual growth, of the *xin*. This could indicate the influence of Mencian philosophy in the *Shuowen*'s explication of *xing*.
12. Ch'en 1953, Ahern 1980, Munro 1969 and A. C. Graham (1967; and 1989: 250ff).
13. Philip Ivanhoe points out the different learning strategies implicated in each philosophy (Ivanhoe 1990). The philosophical distance between the two positions has persisted through developments in Chinese intellectual history and is manifest especially in Neo-Confucian thought (see Hansen 1992: 380 at note 16).
14. Gongsun Long emphasised the absoluteness of titles, assigning them a status that further perpetuated the underlying assumptions of the Confucian rectification of names (aligning names with reality), and also arguing for clear distinctions to be made. Refer to Y. P. Mei (1953) for a translation of the text.
15. There is no clear distinction between those roles within the socio-political and others in personal or private domains. *Zhengming* applies not only to the obligations of those who take on the more 'public' socio-political roles, but to obligations in relationships which have a distinctly more personal and private aspect as well. These discussions on the moral demands arising from relationships provide interesting grounds for comparison with the relatively recent interest in similar issues in contemporary western moral philosophy.
16. The potential for an inept or immoral ruler to manipulate the common people utilising this formulation of *zhengming* is not insignificant. It is a possibility that Xunzi considers only briefly, arguing that those who exploit the tool by recklessly making up new names and casting out the old – hence causing people to be deluded and confused – 'is a terrible evil and should be punished' (*Works of Hsun Tzu* 22: 'The Rectification of Names', trans. Watson 1963: 140).
17. Xunzi writes, 'All those who maintain that desires must be gotten rid of before there can be orderly government fail to consider whether desires can be guided, but merely deplore the fact that they exist at all. All those who maintain that desires must be lessened before there can be orderly government fail to consider whether desires can be controlled, but merely deplore the fact that they are so numerous ... the possession or

nonpossession of desires has nothing to do with good government or bad' (*ibid*: 150).

18. The *Zhongyong* had traditionally been attributed to Confucius' grandson, Zisi. However, more recent scholarship dates it as a text of the Qin or early Han, though with some sections of much earlier origin. De Bary and Bloom's compilation of texts includes translated sections of the text as well as commentary on them (1999: 333–9).
19. Antonio Cua is perhaps the most insightful and prolific contemporary philosopher on the topic of moral theory and ethical cultivation in Confucian thought (in English-language publications). Herbert Fingarette's explanations of Confucian thought (1972, 1979, 1983) also present another interesting way of revitalising Confucian *li*.
20. Sartwell 1993, Fingarette 1983 and Lai 2003b.
21. Traditionally, *junzi* is a term applied to achievements available only to men: social and political status and ethical cultivation. In Confucius' time, the term *junzi* by definition excluded women. But here, I have translated *junzi* as 'paradigmatic person' in order to be gender neutral; after all, not all of the ideals associated with the Confucian *junzi* are out of reach of women today.
22. The distinction between the terms in the early Confucian texts is less than clear and, while there are subtle differences between the two concepts, both relate to shame: *xiu* seems to incorporate the idea of an internal moral-regulatory capacity while *chi* seems to capture the sense of embarrassment associated with being 'caught out'. However, this sense of embarrassment may also be internalised such that one may feel *chi* even in the absence of observers. The predominant concept in the *Analects* is *chi* while Mencius discusses *xiu* especially in connection with *wu*, aversion to evil (Lai 2006: 74–6). Xunzi by contrast does not seem to focus on shame as 'internal' regulation although, for him, shame stands in contrast to the concept of honour (*rong*), a concept closely related to a person's integrity (Cua 2005: 205–43).